

Aishwarya. And it was a blast, like the world tour.

Q. You always get involved in some political controversy or the other, whether it's with Amar Singh, the Thackerays or the Gandhis. What do you have to say?

AB. It's part of life. I don't say anything. People say it.

Q. Do you not feel that being seen as a political person has hampered your public persona?

AB. My conscience, my bearing, and my deeds are there for everyone to see. Once I said I didn't want to return to politics, I've never made any political statement, never stood on any political platform. If there are people who are friends of mine, who are representatives of political parties, then so be it. I'm not their friend because of their politics. If the media is drawing assumptions, they have the right to do so and I have the right to defend myself.

Q. Yet, in almost every poll on Bollywood icons, you are usually at the top of the list.

AB. That's not correct. It should be Shah Rukh Khan.

Q. Aishwarya, you don't even do as many films as your contemporaries, yet you score huge numbers.

AB Jr. I've never understood this question. Almost 30 films is a lot to do in over 10 years. She's not done less work, just the work she wanted to do.

Q. But you never get quoted in this numbers game.

AB Jr. I don't think the amount you get paid is important. I find it quite rude. I'd much rather be spoken about for the quality of my work.

Q. You were described as dyslexic in Taare Zameen

meeting with TV executives where the head of a TV station referred to *Kya Aap Paanchvi Paas Se Tez Hain?* as 'Paanchvi Fail'. The media conveniently shifted that quote to me, which has then created some more controversies. In order to close that, I said I hadn't said so. Even if I had, I apologise. I love my colleagues, I love their success. We're a very close-knit industry that is secular and nationally integrated. There have been many attempts in the past to divide us.

Q. Do you think there was a backlash against you, from the media and the industry, after the wedding be-



“There were severe accusations against my father. As his son, I defended him. When I'm not around, I'd expect my son to do so.” AMITABH

“WHEN I STARTED OFF, PEOPLE TERMED ME A DISGRACE. BUT MY MOTHER, MY FATHER, AND MY WIFE'S ATTITUDE DID NOT CHANGE.” ABHISHEK

Par. How did you overcome it?

AB Jr. I didn't really know about it. When I joined boarding school at Aiglon (in Switzerland), I took a test, and then three-four of us were taken away to a special English class. I was there for a year-and-a-half. I had minor dyslexia.

AB. It's something the school took up and rectified. We didn't even know about it until later.

Q. Mr Bachchan, everyone sees you as the CEO of Brand Bachchan, in charge of the family's collective equity.

AB. This is a fallacy, that there is a figurehead who manages the brand. We're all individuals, we're all professionals. But to look at us as a big mafia family that sits, designs, protects and operates the brand is nonsense.

Q. What about the rivalry with the Khans, and with Shah Rukh Khan in particular?

AB. The media would love to see it because it makes for interesting copy.

Q. What about the 'Paanchvi Fail' remark on your blog for which you apologised later?

AB. I never apologised for anything. And you must get the facts right. I've reproduced in my blog the events of a

cause of the restricted guest list?

AB. I don't know. We're okay with it. I don't know about everybody else.

Q. Abhishek, do you feel the need to reach out to the next generation of Gandhis?

AB Jr. Rahul and Priyanka were much senior to me. We met only occasionally on vacations. But I know them and if the need arises, I will reach out to them.

Q. What lessons do you learn daily from your father and your wife? It takes immense confidence to live with such powerhouses, doesn't it?

AB Jr. It would be wrong to say that it shows a great measure of confidence. It's unconditional love. These other aspects of them being such great professionals is secondary. If you love someone enough, it doesn't really matter. When I started my career, a lot of people termed me a disgrace. My mother, my father, and my wife's attitude—because I've worked with her before—did not change.

Q. Thank you all very much. My only request to Mr Bachchan is that he lighten up a bit.

AB. I'm very light. I've lost 5 kg in the past few weeks.